2.3 NATIONAL GEOGRAPHIC PHOTOGRAPHER KEN GARRETT



Photographer Ken Garrett makes a rare appearance in front of the lens at the Burnside Bridge near the Antietam battlefield in Maryland.

"When the photo reaches a wide audience and makes a difference in how we see the world, that is what makes it rewarding."

–Ken Garrett

Through the Lens—Civil War Photography

For more than 40 years, National Geographic photographer Ken Garrett has documented images of past civilizations for *National Geographic* magazine. He has traveled to every continent, exploring and photographing ancient artifacts and ruins. But his passion for documenting the land and events associated with America's rich history keeps Garrett closer to home. He has found a wealth of subjects to photograph on the Civil War.

Garrett tells the stories of fallen Civil War soldiers through images of famous battlefields and reenactments. He hopes to help people learn from the past and use that knowledge to understand events today. His photographs of Civil War sites are a reminder of the blood shed on both sides of the conflict. The photos convey the emotions, confusion, and determination of the soldiers who fought on what Garrett refers to as "hallowed ground."

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Lincoln Cemetery in Gettysburg, Pennsylvania, is the burial site of about 30 members of the U.S. Colored Troops. During the Civil War, African-American veterans were prohibited from being buried in the Soldiers' National Cemetery. In this photo taken by Garrett, reenactors pay tribute to African-American Civil War veterans during a Remembrance Day parade.

SIZING UP A SITE

When Garrett photographs a Civil War site, he likes to scout the area with a guide who can help him understand the events of the historic battle. The guide's insights help Garrett determine how to use his camera to capture the decisions made during the battle. He uses photography to show why one place was important to defend or what made another a superior place in which to hide, prepare, and attack.

Battery-powered lighting equipment helps Garrett capture the right photograph in the right light or season. "You should try to photograph a site during the season when the action took place," he adds. For example, by photographing Brandy Station, Virginia, during the summer, Garrett was able to provide insight into the heat and humidity both armies endured at this site of the largest cavalry battle in U.S. history.

Gettysburg is Garrett's favorite Civil War battlefield to photograph. "It is a very emotional place, where you really get an understanding of the horror of war. The thought that those boys walked out into that open field to be killed, sometimes by their own brothers, is a shocking realization." Gettysburg is also a popular site for reenactments. These re-creations put contemporary people in the shoes of people from 150 years earlier, bringing history to life and giving us valuable perspective on historic events.

A selection of Garrett's Gettysburg photographs as well as others from his Civil War collection are included in the following photo essay on the Civil War.

HISTORICAL THINKING

MAKE CONNECTIONS Why are Ken Garrett's Civil War photographs relevant today?

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